One major problem in Western responses to Buddhism is to see it as an essentially benign religion and as a uniform confessional group. Thus, to many, Buddhism is the Dalai Lama speaking out about oppression and for peace, and representing Tibet against Chinese domination. Equally, it has connotations of yoga, meditation and the modern psychological technique of ‘mindfulness’. All these images are valid but they are not the complete story.

Theravada Buddhism had split from Indian–Tibetan Mahayana Buddhism by the fifth century AD and took root in three states—today’s Sri Lanka, Myanmar and Thailand. Buddhism places emphasis on religion’s role in the wider polity, besides individual devotion. The state should support Buddhist institutions and the Buddhist hierarchy and seek to drive out or minimise non-Buddhist influences. It was partly this mindset that led the Burmese kings to conquer Arakan in the 1780s.

In effect, the Theravada tradition has potentially a very exclusive model of the acceptable social structure. At the least, any non-Buddhists are accorded less value, and quite often this can lead to ethnic tensions (where ethnicity and religion overlap). It is no accident that Buddhism is closely associated with violent inter-ethnic tensions in Sri Lanka and Thailand as well as in Myanmar. This creates several major problems for resolving the situation in Myanmar. First, several prominent Buddhist groups are actively driving the anti-Muslim violence, and second, if for slightly different reasons, both the NLD and the USDP are dependent on the approval of the Buddhist hierarchies. Within Rakhine the situation is made more extreme by the disenfranchisement of the Rohingyas and the extent to which both the NLD and the USDP are competing with ethnic and Buddhist confessional parties for the votes of the Rakhine.

Add on over forty years of telling the majority of people who live in Myanmar that the Rohingyas are really citizens of another country and have no place in Myanmar, and this leads to a significant problem. In effect, as some in the NLD have finally acknowledged,[6] the situation is now so bad that the only outcomes are to ease the level of persecution or for it to slip into outright genocide.

This presents a worrying picture. There are few internal factors that will enable Myanmar to step back from the now complete exclusion of the Rohingyas from civil life. If genocide is to be averted, this exclusion must